

U.S. COVERT POLITICAL INTERVENTIONS IN CHILE FROM 1970-1973

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Chile's two chronologically successive presidents, Salvador Allende and Augusto Pinochet, embodied opposing political visions. Allende was the world's first democratically elected socialist president and sought to implement socialism in Chile through democratic reforms, while Pinochet was an anti-communist authoritarian ruler who established a 17-year dictatorship. Following Pinochet's coup d'état in 1973, his regime became responsible for more than 40,000 victims from torture, executions, detentions, and disappearances. The drastic political shift from democracy to authoritarianism was not solely the result of internal division but was also influenced by foreign interference, particularly from the United States. When Allende won the presidency on September 4, 1970, U.S. policymakers likely perceived his victory as a threat to hemispheric unity and the spread of Marxist ideology, which could be a major setback for America's power in global politics. Just eleven days after Allende's election, President Richard Nixon reportedly ordered officials to "overthrow Allende," initiating covert interventions funded by \$8 million to "bring him down." Although the United States publicly maintained a stance of neutrality, its covert political interventions during the three years of Allende's presidency destabilized democracy in Chile, creating a "coup climate" that helped lay the foundation for Augusto Pinochet's brutal dictatorship.

Fueled by the desire to preserve its geopolitical self-interest, the United States carried out covert political interventions, ranging from supporting anti-Allende propaganda to funding labor strikes, which contributed to social unrest during the three years of Allende's presidency. Before assuming office, Allende pledged to nationalize US-owned copper industries, indirectly challenging American economic dominance in Chile. Meanwhile, because Allende's election occurred amid the Cold War, Nixon perceived Allende not only as a domestic reformer but also as a potential ally of the Soviet Union who could expand socialist ideologies throughout the Western Hemisphere. Within two days of Allende's inauguration, Nixon convened the National Security Council to discuss ways to "bring about his downfall." Nixon's opposition to Allende's government transformed from polit-

ical anxiety into a series of calculated covert interventions after he convened the National Security Council on November 6, 1970. Initially, government officials from the council, including Secretary of State William Rogers and Secretary of Defense Melvin Laird, merely expressed their desires to 'bring [Allende] down.' However, under Henry Kissinger's explicit prodding to broaden the scope of covert operations, the council transformed rhetoric into action by drafting an eight-page "Covert Action Program for Chile" in mid-November. With a \$7 million operational budget, the program was designed by the CIA "in an effort to maximize pressure on the Allende government." The rapid transition, occurring within a month, in which the United States transitioned from an ideological containment to an active program, proved the calculated measures the United States took to destabilize Allende's government from the very beginning. The first major covert action occurred in September 1971, when the United States funded \$700,000 to channel "anti-Allende propaganda" in Chile's largest newspaper, the *El Mercurio*. By 1972, the newspaper was "publishing almost daily editorials criticizing the Allende Government," becoming the "loudest opposition voice" and guiding force in shaping Chilean public opinion against Allende. Simultaneously, the United States cut off economic aid, denied credits, and imposed an "invisible blockade" through U.S. commercial banks to tighten the economic "squeeze" on Chile. Amidst Allende's policies to reform the labor force, this intentional "squeeze" intensified economic pressure on Chilean workers, particularly those in the mining and transportation sectors. While the United States exacerbated political and economic tensions, Allende also faced shortcomings within his own policies. The March of the Empty Pots, a protest involving over ten thousand protestors, initially stemmed from the dissatisfaction with Allende's failure to support women's labor rights. However, his dissatisfaction was exacerbated by the US-funded "special propaganda campaigns," which sought to convince women that Allende's government would threaten their families' livelihoods. The protest thus reflected the broader dual dynamic, in which the United States magnified existing Chilean dissatisfaction with Allende's policy. By financing protests and amplifying political polarization, the United States fostered an atmosphere of economic chaos and social unrest. As *The New York Times* reported in 1974, the "CIA secretly financed Chilean labor union strikes for more than 18 months" before the coup. Several agencies later admitted that these covert interventions by the United States played "a significant role in setting the stage" for Pinochet's coup d'état. By 1973, the United States achieved the objective that Nixon's administration outlined in November 1970: to "destabilize Chile until the country was ungovernable."

By the narrowest definition of a “direct role,” the United States and CIA do not appear to have been involved in the violent actions of Pinochet’s coup d’état. In September 1974, Kissinger testified before the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, stating that “the intent of the United States was not to destabilize [Allende]” and the Nixon administration had “nothing to do” with the coup. However, historical records of the United States’ strategic covert interventions – including funding labor strikes, anti-Allende propaganda in newspapers, and issuing an economic blockade — prove otherwise. Following Nixon’s presidency, President Gerald Ford publicly defended U.S. intervention against Allende, asserting that the actions were “in the best interests of the people of Chile and certainly in [the United States’s] best interest.” Ultimately, Pinochet’s 1973 coup d’état in Chile was not only a tragic chapter marked by human rights abuses, but also a powerful example of how foreign interferences, driven by national self-interest, can undermine sovereign democracy.

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